

Introduction to Omeka & Dublin Core



HIST 5237: Issues and Methods in Public History

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Workshop Agenda

- Introduction: what is Omeka and what are digital archives?
- Review and discussion of digital projects built with Omeka
- Introduction: Dublin Core metadata standard
- Demonstration: Omeka.net
- Omeka best practices

Add github link

Introduction to Omeka

What is Omeka? (Part 1)



- Developed by the [Corporation for Digital Scholarship](#) (CDS), a non-profit started in 2009 at the [Roy Rosenzweig Center for History and New Media](#) at George Mason University.
- CDS maintains and funds a host of open access tools for researchers and cultural heritage institutions including: [Zotero](#), [Tropy](#), [PressForward](#), [Sourcery](#), and [Omeka](#).

What is Omeka? (Part 2)

- Omeka is a **web publishing platform** for **items, exhibits, and collections**
- Designed with scholars, librarians, educators and archivists in mind, Omeka emphasizes the role of **metadata** in **archiving** and **curation**
- Omeka offers the ability to contextualize items & bring them into conversation with one another
- Omeka makes it easy to create and update metadata using **Dublin Core** standards, a general vocabulary for describing digital or physical items

Versions of Omeka

There are three different versions of Omeka, each with their own benefits for different types of audiences, institutions, and users.

Omeka.net:
provides free and
priced plan options,
including support
and hosting by
Omeka (CDS).

Omeka Classic: built for
individuals or educators
where each site requires
a different installation,
including separate
hosting (domain/URL).

Omeka S: built for
institutions managing
a sharable resource
pool across multiple
sites or other
collections and
resources.

Properties of Omeka

Like other web-publishing platforms (like Squarespace or WordPress), different versions of Omeka come with customization features, like **plugins** and **themes**.

- **Plugins:** pieces of software that add new features or functionality to existing applications.
- **Themes:** foundational design of a website, including typography, color palettes, layout, header and footers, backgrounds, etc.

Digital Archive Vocabulary

- **Collections:** a group of items arranged around a particular subject.
- **Exhibits:** pages created to showcase archival items or collections around subjects, to tell a story or narrative, or convey a specific message. Materials are usually accompanied by interpretive text.
- **Metadata:** a type of data that provides information about or describes data, like the fields “author,” “title,” and “place of publication” for a book in a library catalog system.

Group Activity: Explore and Discuss Omeka Projects

Example Omeka Projects

Many projects use Omeka to organize, describe, and exhibit archival materials. Here are a few examples:

- [A Journal of the Plague Year](#)
- [Dental Instruments Past & Present](#)
- [1918 Flu Pandemic in Utah](#)
- [Narcotic City Archive](#)

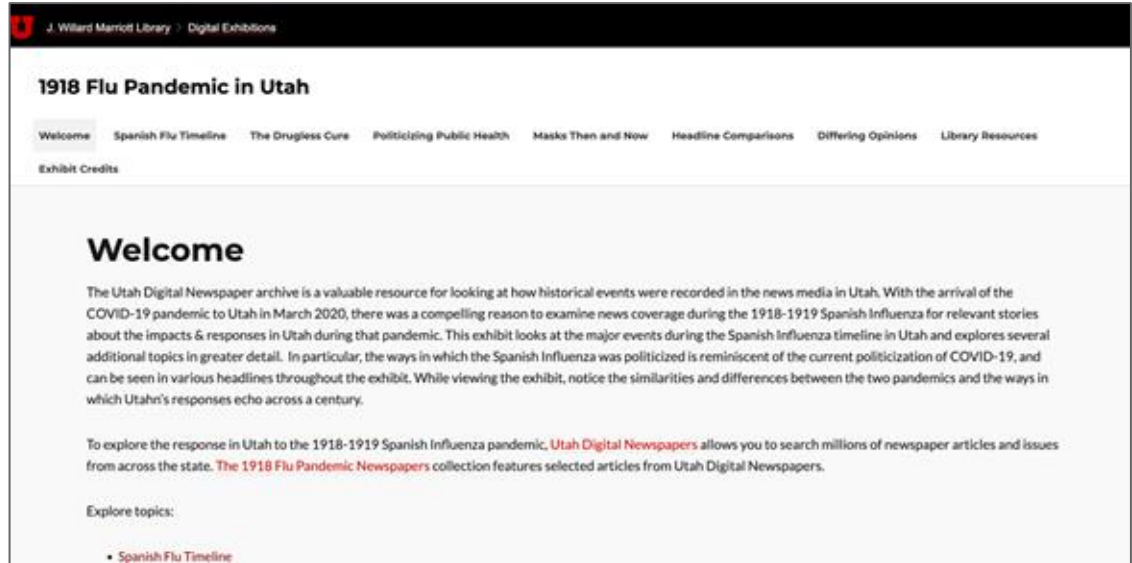
A Journal of the Plague Year

The [A Journal of the Plague Year](#) is an archive of COVID-19 pandemic. This is an interactive project that crowdsources stories to contribute to the archive. It utilizes interactive digital humanities methods.



1918 Flu Pandemic in Utah

[1918 Flu Pandemic in Utah](#) is a digital newspaper archive for the Spanish Influenza. The project is interested in looks to find out more about the way the Spanish Flu was documented in the news and compare that to Covid-19.



Discussion Questions

- What metadata fields did these projects use?
 - Are any surprising to you?
- How did the metadata fields differ across the projects?
- How did the projects' use of Omeka differ?
- Why do you think Omeka was chosen for these projects over something like WordPress or Squarespace? How might these sites look different if they were hosted on one of those platforms?

Dublin Core

Metadata Standards: Dublin Core

Metadata Standards: a shared system used by projects and institutions to structure and understand data, including principles and rules for implementing the description and categorization of data.

[Dublin Core](#): first created in 1995, this standard includes elements to describe items in information systems and is used by many groups.

Dublin Core Specifics

- Dublin Core was created to support open cultural heritage data.
- It is designed to be simple and flexible, which has both advantages and disadvantages.
- Fields include: title, contributor, creator, date, subject, description, format, identifier, language, publisher, relation, rights, source, and type.

Dublin Core Best Practices

- All the fields are optional, so you can choose which you want to use to describe the items in your archive; be strategic about which fields you select!
- It is essential to have consistency in metadata fields across your items: both in which you select and in how you fill those in (for instance, you don't want to have "Firstname Lastname" in half your "creator" fields and "Lastname, Firstname" in the other half)

Tool

Demonstration:

Omeka.net

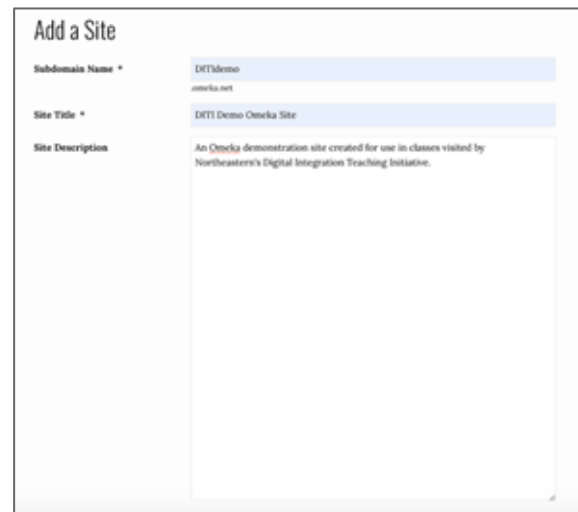
Key Omeka Terms

- **Items:** the individual files, artifacts, books, or discrete pieces of data added to Omeka.
- **Item Types:** categorizations given to items in Omeka that can include things like text, still image, person, email, building, etc.
- **Exhibits:** pages created to showcase archival items or collections around subjects, to tell a story or narrative, or convey a specific message in interpretive text.
- **Exhibit Pages:** website pages on Omeka for different exhibits, complete with different formats including gallery, text, file, etc.
- **Tags:** a description “marker” added to items that is used in web-based approaches for managing information across collections and exhibits

Creating Your Omeka Account

- Go to:
<https://www.omeka.net/signup>
- Choose a trial plan
- Click on the activation link sent to your email
- Then, under “Add a Site,” enter a subdomain name (for the URL), site title, and site description.
- Once you have added your site, click ‘Manage site’ to navigate to the site’s dashboard.

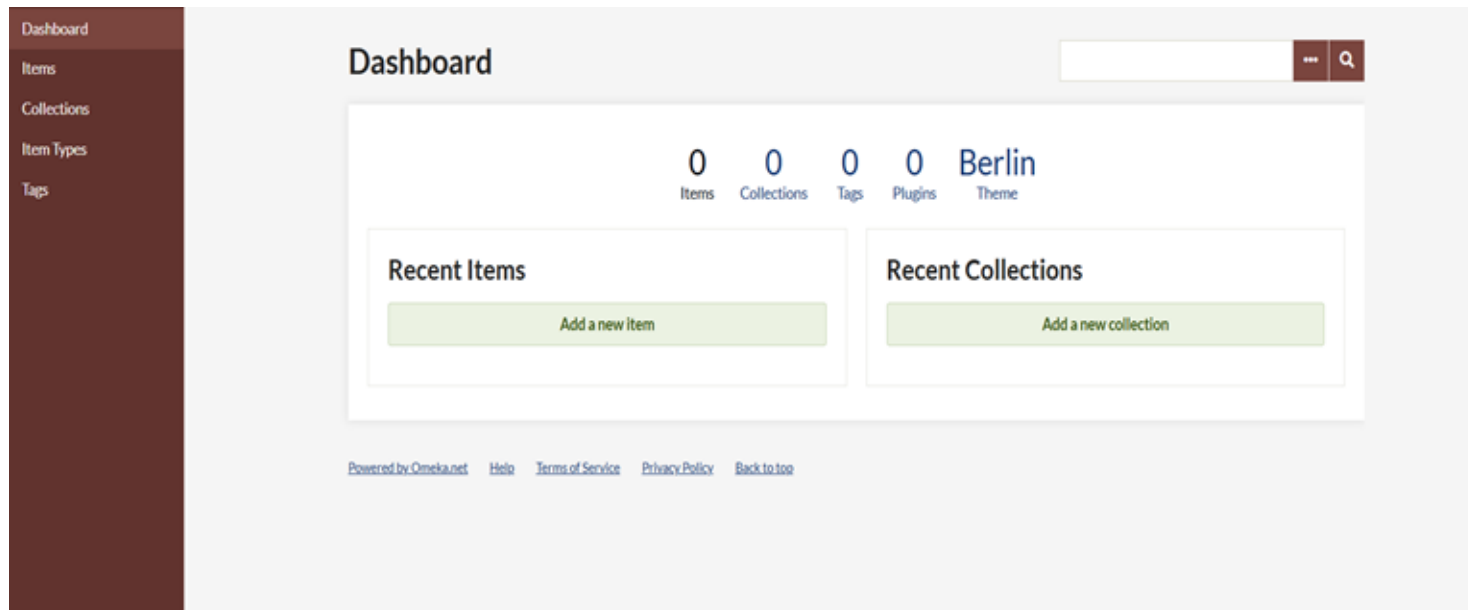
Note: Once you create the site (with the trial on Omeka.net) you can't set it to private. **But** you can control whether individual items, exhibits, or pages are private.



The screenshot shows the 'Add a Site' form in Omeka.net. It has three input fields: 'Subdomain Name *' with the value 'DITdemo', 'Site Title *' with the value 'DITI Demo Omeka Site', and 'Site Description' with the value 'An Omeka demonstration site created for use in classes visited by Northeastern's Digital Integration Teaching Initiative.' The form is styled with a light blue header and a white body.

Add a Site	
Subdomain Name *	DITdemo
Site Title *	DITI Demo Omeka Site
Site Description	An Omeka demonstration site created for use in classes visited by Northeastern's Digital Integration Teaching Initiative.

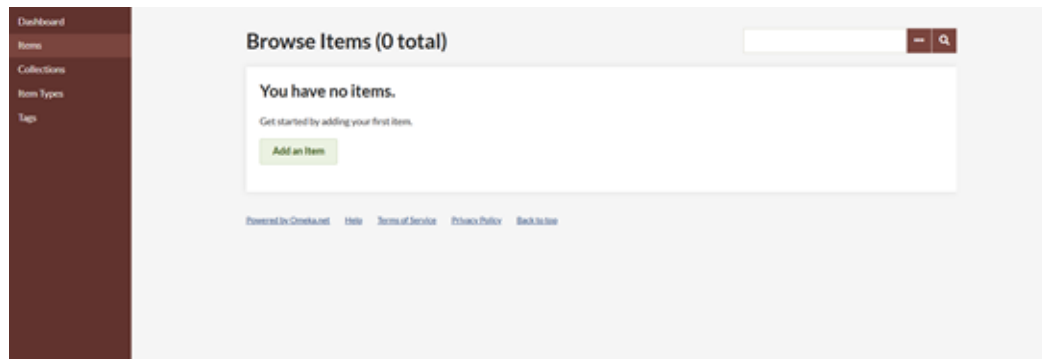
Omeka Dashboard



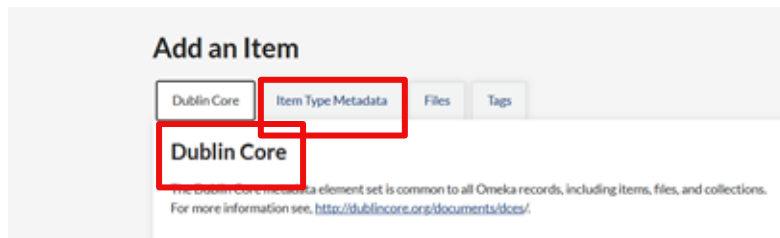
Navigation

Adding Items

- Under the “Items” tab, click “Add an Item”
 - You can upload multiple files for one item
 - You can choose whether to make an item public or not
 - You can edit items once they are added
- Then, add metadata!

A screenshot of the 'Add Item' form. At the top is a green button labeled 'Add Item'. Below it are two checkboxes: 'Public: ☐' and 'Featured: ☐'. The 'Public' checkbox is highlighted with a red border. Below these is a section titled 'Collection' with a dropdown menu that says 'Select Below' and a downward arrow.

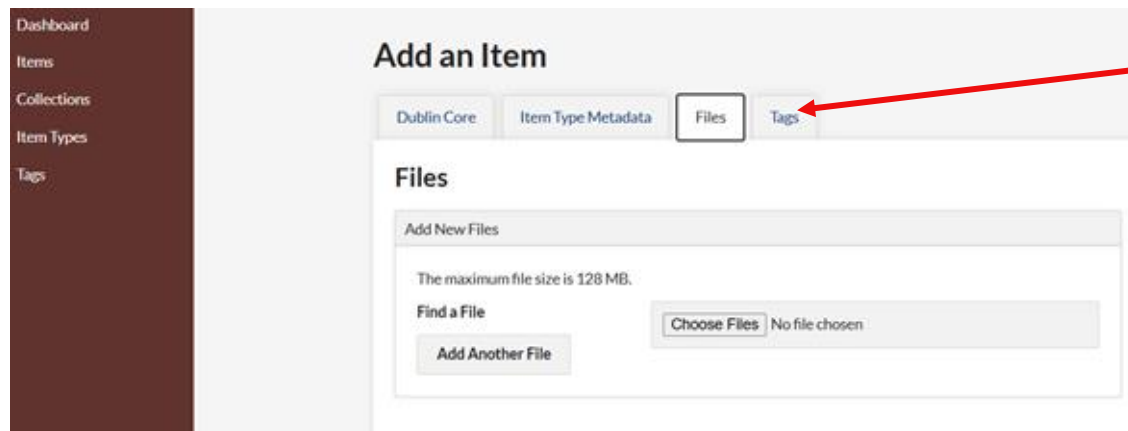
Adding Metadata



- Dublin Core vs. Item Type Metadata
 - Dublin Core is the basic information that will be relevant **across items**
 - Item Type Metadata is additional information that is likely to be **relevant for specific item types** (e.g. duration for moving images, or subject line for emails)
- You can add additional input fields (for both types of metadata)
- Formatting text in metadata fields
 - If you click "Use HTML" you will get more formatting options
 - You can also enter basic HTML to make formatting edits that are not available in the default editor; for more information on the HTML editor, visit [Omeka's guide to HTML editing](#).

Adding Files to Items

- You can add multiple files to an item
- If you have more than one file, you can drag the order of files to change which one appears as the key image



Add files
here

File-Specific Metadata (1/2)

- You can add metadata for the **files** that you attach to your **items**
 - In this instance, the item is the Boston Dispensary building, and the file attached to the item is the image of it
- **File metadata does not appear automatically.** Once you upload an image, you need to click “edit” to get to the metadata.
- Example on following slide,

File-Specific Metadata

Edit file-specific
metadata here

File-specific
metadata

The screenshot shows a digital library interface. On the left is a dark red sidebar with navigation links: Dashboard, Items, Collections, Item Types, and Tags. The main content area is titled 'Item #1: "An early hospital"' and includes a search bar. A green banner at the top of the item page states 'The item "An early hospital" was successfully changed!'. Below this is a small image of a building. A red box highlights the 'Dublin Core' metadata section, which contains the following information:

Dublin Core	
Title	An early hospital
Subject	Boston Dispensary 1811
Creator	William R. Lawrence
Source	Wikipedia
Publisher	A History of the Boston Dispensary, printed by J. Wilson
Date	1859

Below the Dublin Core section, there are three buttons: 'Edit' (highlighted with a red box), 'View Public Page', and 'Delete'. Further down, there are sections for 'Public: Yes Featured: No', 'Collection' (No Collection), and 'File Metadata' (1859 BostonDispensary AshStreet 8 ennetStreet.org).

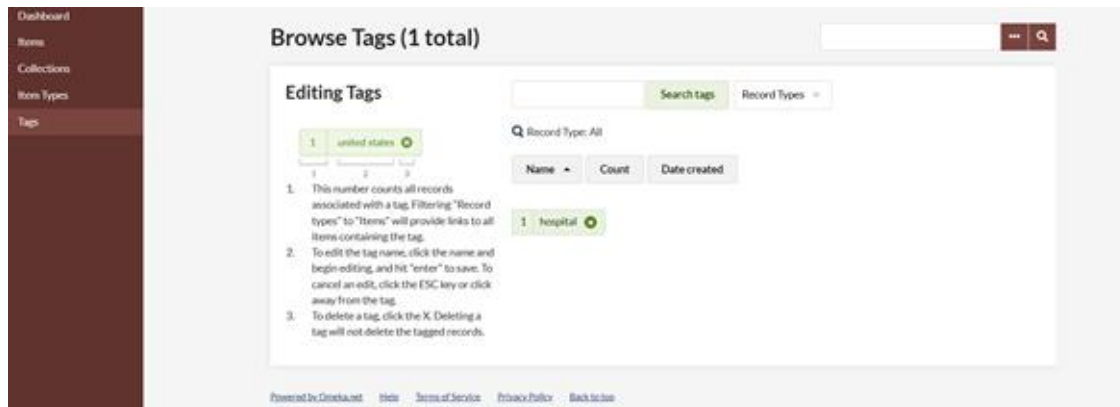
Organizing Items: Tags and Collections

- Items can have **multiple** tags, but they can only have **one** collection
- Origin: Tagging is more of a web-focused approach to managing information, whereas collections are from physical archiving, where every item is in a single collection



Adding and Editing Tags

- You **tag items** through editing an item
- You **edit tags** through the “tags” tab



Adding
a tag to
an item

Editing
tags

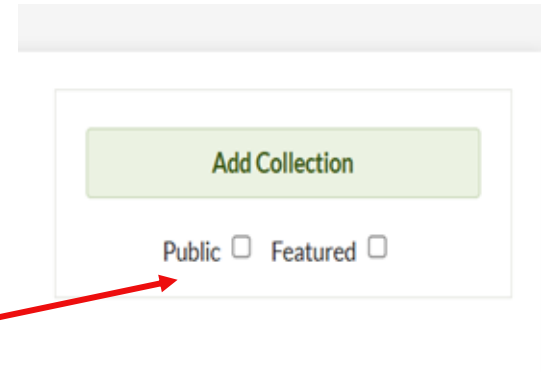
Editing Tags, continued

Make sure your tags are consistent!



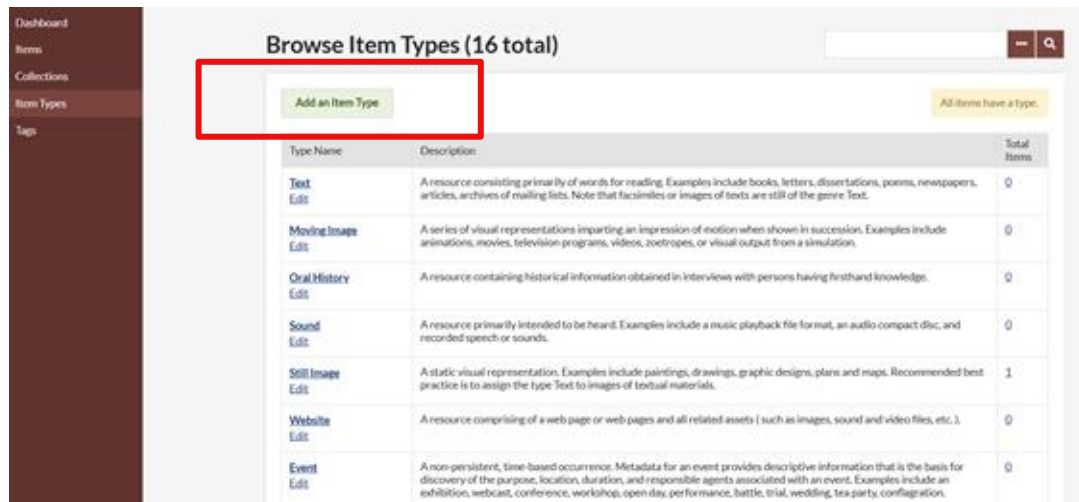
Adding Collections

- Unlike tags, you create a collection before adding items to it
- Adding a collection is a lot like adding an item
 - Under the collections tab, click “Add Collection”
- Remember: items can only belong to one collection
- You can choose whether to make a collection public or not with these boxes



Item Types

- **Item types** are the different categorizations you can assign to an item. These include text, still image, person, email, etc.
- You can edit item types by clicking on “edit,” under the Item Types tab.
- There, you can edit the **description** of an item type and its elements.
- **Elements** are the different attributes of an item type.



Browse Item Types (16 total)

[Add Item Type](#)

All items have a type.

Type Name	Description	Total Items
Text Edit	A resource consisting primarily of words for reading. Examples include books, letters, dissertations, poems, newspapers, articles, archives of mailing lists. Note that facsimiles or images of texts are still of the genre Text.	0
Moving Image Edit	A series of visual representations imparting an impression of action when shown in succession. Examples include animations, movies, television programs, videos, zoetropes, or visual output from a simulation.	0
Oral History Edit	A resource containing historical information obtained in interviews with persons having firsthand knowledge.	0
Sound Edit	A resource primarily intended to be heard. Examples include a music playback file format, an audio compact disc, and recorded speech or sounds.	0
Still Image Edit	A static visual representation. Examples include paintings, drawings, graphic designs, plans and maps. Recommended best practice is to assign the type Text to images of textual materials.	1
Website Edit	A resource comprising of a web page or web pages and all related assets (such as images, sound and video files, etc.).	0
Event Edit	A non-persistent, time-based occurrence. Metadata for an event provides descriptive information that is the basis for discovery of the purpose, location, duration, and responsible agents associated with an event. Examples include an exhibition, webcast, conference, workshop, open day, performance, battle, trial, wedding, tea-party, configuration.	0

Editing Elements for Item Types

- You can add **existing elements** from a list or **create new ones**
- You can also remove the default elements for an item type (but make sure you think carefully before doing this!)

Elements

The screenshot shows a web interface for managing elements. At the top, under the heading 'Elements', there is a list of three existing elements: 'Text', 'Original Format', and 'Element Name'. Each element has a small icon on the left and a remove button (an 'x' in a square) on the right. Below this list is a form for adding a new element. It has a label 'Element Name' followed by a text input field. Below that is a label 'Element Description' followed by a larger text area. At the bottom of the form, there is a section titled 'Add Element' containing two radio buttons: 'Existing' and 'New'. The 'New' radio button is selected. Below the radio buttons is a button labeled 'Add Element'.

Adding New Item Types

You can add completely new item types by clicking the “Add an Item Type” button, giving the new item type a name and description, and adding elements to it (either existing or new).

Browse Item Types (16 total)

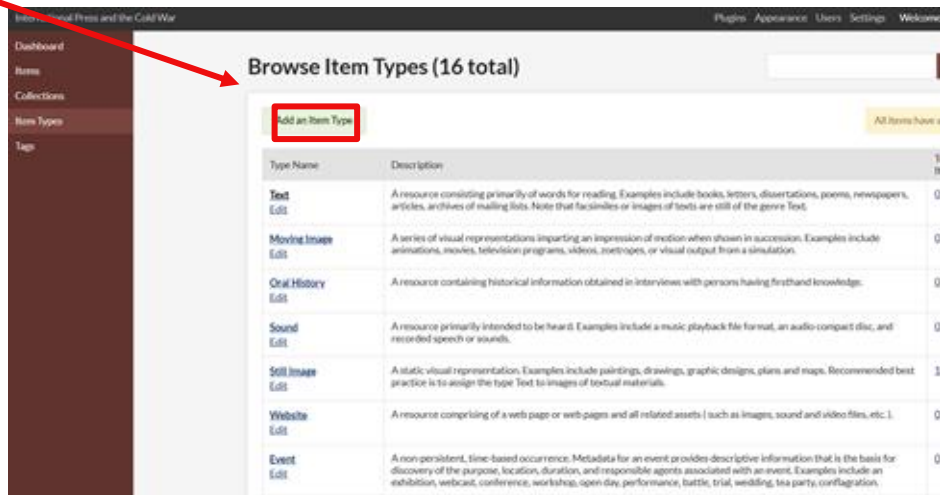
[Add an Item Type](#)

All items have a type.

Type Name	Description	Total Items
Text Edit	A resource consisting primarily of words for reading. Examples include books, letters, dissertations, poems, newspapers, articles, archives of mailing lists. Note that facsimiles or images of texts are still of the genre Text.	0
Moving Image Edit	A series of visual representations imparting an impression of motion when shown in succession. Examples include animations, movies, television programs, videos, zoetropes, or visual output from a simulation.	0
Oral History Edit	A resource containing historical information obtained in interviews with persons having firsthand knowledge.	0
Sound Edit	A resource primarily intended to be heard. Examples include a music playback file format, an audio compact disc, and recorded speech or sounds.	0
Still Image Edit	A static visual representation. Examples include paintings, drawings, graphic designs, plans and maps. Recommended best practice is to assign the type Text to images of textual materials.	1

Plugins

- To create **simple pages** and **exhibits**, you first need to install these plugins
- Click “Plugins” in the top menu and install Simple Pages and Exhibit Builder



Creating Simple Pages (1/2)

- **Simple pages** allow you to create web pages for your digital archive
- To add a page, click “Add a Page” under the “Simple Pages” tab. You can then add a title and edit the slug, or page URL

Establish navigation by designating parent pages and page order

The screenshot shows the 'Simple Pages | Add Page' form. On the left is a dark sidebar with a menu containing 'Dashboard', 'Items', 'Collections', 'Item Types', 'Tags', 'Simple Pages', and 'Exhibits'. The 'Simple Pages' tab is selected. The main form area has the title 'Simple Pages | Add Page'. It contains several fields: 'Title' (required), 'Slug', 'Use HTML editor?' (checkbox), and a 'Text' area. To the right of these fields are instructions and a 'Check this to add an HTML editor' checkbox. Further right is the 'Parent' section with a dropdown menu currently set to 'Main Page (No Parent)'. Below that is an 'Order' field. At the bottom right is a 'Publish this page?' checkbox. Two red arrows point from the text 'Establish navigation by designating parent pages and page order' to the 'Parent' dropdown and the 'Publish this page?' checkbox.

This shortcode indicates that we want all items in Collection 1 to be included on this page

You can choose whether to make the page public

Creating Simple Pages (2/2)

- You choose items for your page by entering **Omeka shortcodes** into the text box (you can also use the text box just for text). A complete list of shortcodes can be found [on the Omeka website](#), but useful ones include:
 - [items collection=**1**]
 - [items item_type="**still image**"]
 - [items tags=**commercial,educational**]

Creating Exhibits

- **Exhibits** are a more robust way to provide access to (and curate!) the contents of your archive. Exhibits are composed of pages (which in turn showcase items).
 - To add an exhibit, click “Add an Exhibit” under the Exhibits tab
 - From here, you can give the exhibit a title, a slug, a credit line, and a description. You can also apply tags and choose a theme and cover image, and decide what you want the starting page to be.
- **You can add existing pages to your exhibit or create new ones**
- Even when you are adding an existing page to your exhibit, you can only establish the **layout** of items on the page through the Exhibits tab

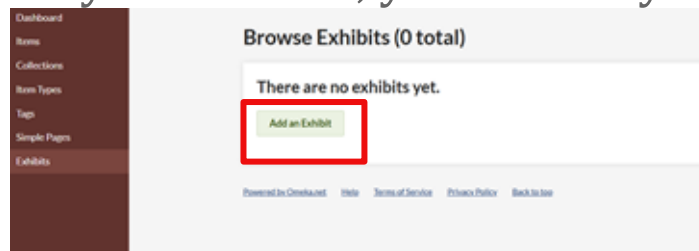


Exhibit Pages

- The contents of exhibit pages are organized by **blocks**
- Layout options for blocks are: file with text, gallery, text, file, and carousel.
- Once you choose your layout option for a block, you can select the items to include
- Although some of the layout options display thumbnail images, you are curating the **item, not the attached file(s)**, in your exhibit

Content

Expand All

Collapse All

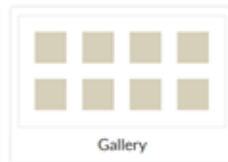
To reorder blocks and items, click and drag them to the preferred location.

New Block

Select layout



File with Text



Gallery



Text



File

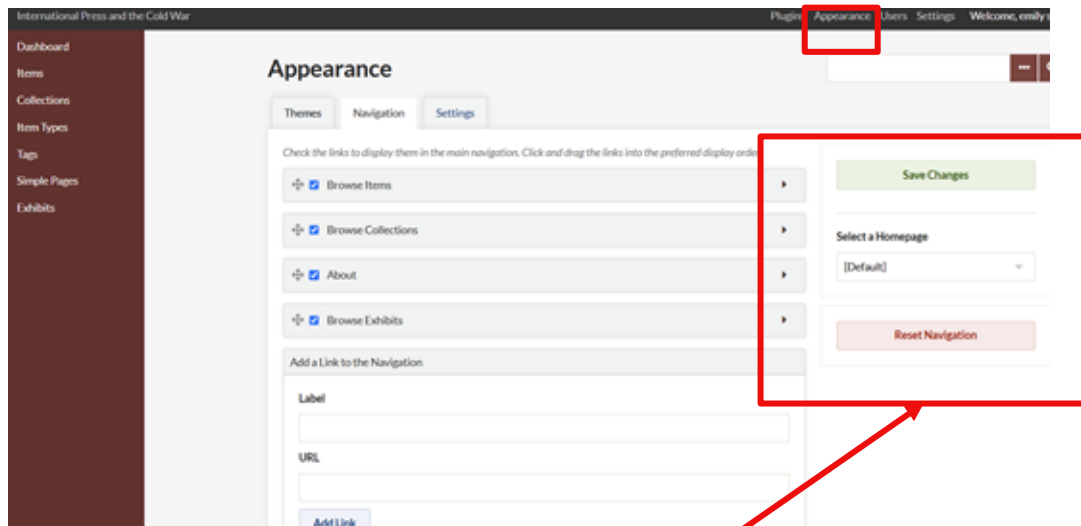


Carousel

Themes and Site Appearance

Under the Appearance tab in the top menu:

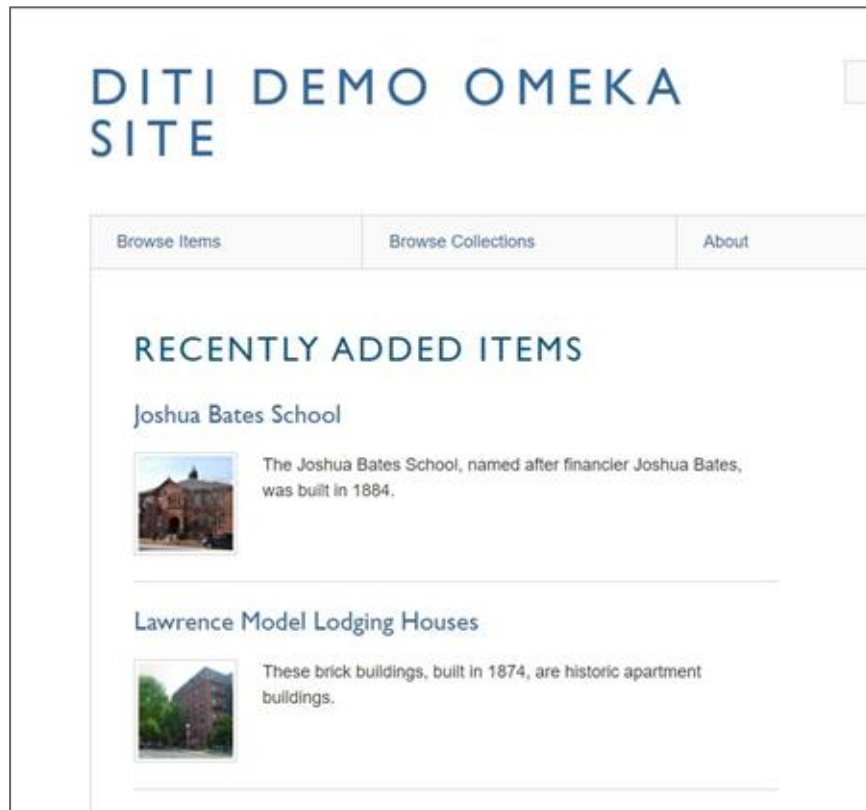
- “Themes” allows you to choose a visual theme
- “Navigation” allows you to control the main menu bar
- “Settings” offers some display choices, including how metadata appears and how thumbnails work



The default homepage is recent items but you can change this

Demo

- [Boston from End to End: NHRP sites in Boston's North and South Ends](#)
- Note: this is a demo of Omeka basics, not an actual archive project!



Omeka + Archival Project Best Practices

Website Hosting

- Paid versions of Omeka include **hosting** and support of maintenance on the CDS servers.
- **Omeka.net** includes a free “trial” account to build a single page with limited themes and plugins, but uses the same code as Omeka Classic; trial Omeka sites can be kept active indefinitely, there's no time limit.
- Hosting is important because it is integral to site sustainability, maintenance, domain URL, project identity.
- [Reclaim Hosting](#) is an organization used by many academics for web hosting with domain registration. They offer lower-cost hosting plans and provide helpful customer services and support.

Data Privacy and Maintenance on Omeka

- Omeka Services collects certain data about you, site visitors, and digital content stored on their platform. It is good practice to review the [Omeka privacy policy](#) to know how this data is used, stored, and managed.
- Omeka is *not* meant for long-term preservation without maintenance. Curators are responsible for updating materials on Omeka following version upgrades.

Digital Accessibility

- Omeka Classic includes accessibility features for both the front end and back end. See their [Accessibility Statement](#) for more details.
- Externally-developed themes and digital content may not be accessible for assistive tech users. Review the accessibility of your digital archive to make sure users can access archived materials.
- See the [DITI Handout on Accessibility in Digital Content](#) for more resources and tips.

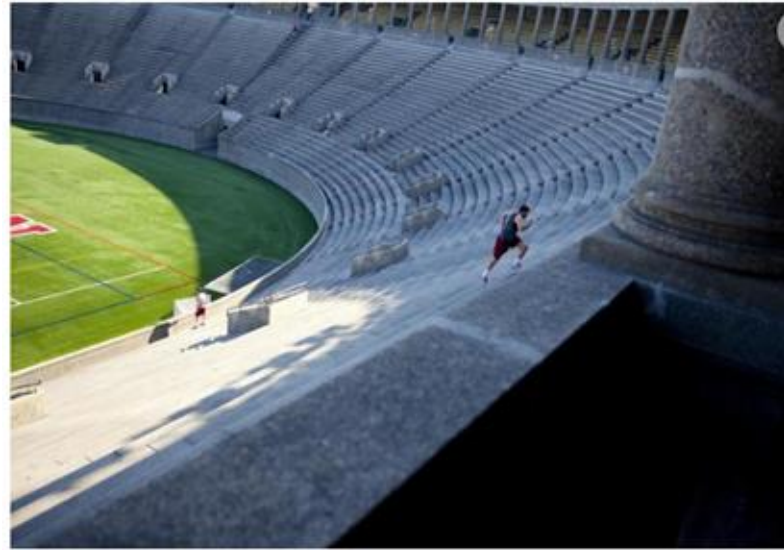
Adding alt text (part 1)

- Alt text is a description of an image that conveys the image content, meaning, and context. This descriptive text is attached to the image file metadata. For more information see the [Northeastern Library Guidelines](#) for alt text.
- People with low or no vision can use assistive technology like screen readers to hear the alt text description of digital images. When a screen reader reaches the image, it will read aloud the alt text description.

Adding alt text (part 2)

- Fill in the Title or Description field when you add an image, sound, or video file.
- Write a description of the image. For audio and video files, write a transcript of what is said, as well as describe the content, context, and purpose of the audio or video file.
- Check out [the example](#) to the right, created by Harvard University.

Example of Alt Text with Various Contexts



Alt-text with no context:

A mostly empty stadium.

Alt-text on a page about recent turnout for track tryouts:

Harvard Stadium with two lone runners bounding up the steps.

Alt-text on page about renovation projects:

Harvard Stadium with cracked concrete pillars.

Your Turn!

Set up your subdomain and Omeka site for your account. Then, try the following:

- Adding 2 or 3 items
- Creating a collection and adding items to that collection
- Tagging items
- Editing an existing item type
- Creating a new item type

Thank you!

Developed by: Claire Lavarreda, Juniper Johnson, Dipa Desai, Talia Brenner, Adam Tomasi, Sarah Connell, Patrick Murray-John, Kasya O'Connor Grant, and Sara Morrell

- For more information on DITI, please see: <https://bit.ly/diti-about>
- Schedule an appointment with us! <https://bit.ly/diti-meeting>
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com